NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥10

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥9

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K Q 4 ♥ J 8 3 ♦ 9 8 ♣ A K 6 2	
♠ 10 5 ♥ A K 6 5 ♦ J 10 3 ♣ Q J 9 5	N W E S	♠ 7 3 ♥ 10 9 7 4 ♦ K 7 6 5 4 2 ♣ 10
	♠ J 9 8 6 2 ♥ Q 2 ♦ A Q ♣ 8 7 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥10

Partner expects you to bid 2♠.

But your hand has suddenly increased in value - with the known ♠ fit you add another point for your doubleton and you have 18 points. So you jump to 3♠; this is called a Super-Accept. But so what. Partner just bids the game anyway.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥10. West plays the ♥K, then ♥A, then ♥5.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 5

You need to eliminate two losers. If East has the ♦K a finesse will save one loser. If ♣s split 3-2 that will eliminate one loser. And of course your ♥J is ready to provide an immediate discard.

So what are you going to discard right now on that ♥J? It looks obvious to discard the ♦Q; then if the ♣s do split 3-2 (68% chance) you will be home free, losing only two ♥s and one♣.

Throwing the ♦Q is a bad idea. And basically unnecessary. If the ♣s are splitting 3-2 you don't need to keep a fourth ♣ in both hands. So discard a small ♣ from dummy and keep the ♦Q just in case the ♣s turn out 4-1 and you have to fall back on the ♦ finesse.

Looking at all four hands you can see why you needed to keep the ♦Q.

After you pull trumps you play the top two ♣s and discover (too late) that you cannot set up a ♣ winner.

But what if the ♦K was actually with West, and the ♣s were splitting 3-2 all the time?

In this scenario it is still ok to discard a small ♣ from dummy.

You pull trumps first, then play two top ♣s. When both defenders follow you give up a ♣. East wins and plays a ♦, but you go up with dummy's ♦A, enter your hand with a trump and **NOW** discard that ♦Q on your good ♣.

Board 2
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 6 2 ♥ Q J 10 8 4 3 ♦ 9 3 ♣ 8 4	
♠ K J 4 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A 7 4 2 ♣ Q 10 6 2	N W E S	♠ Q 10 9 ♥ A K 2 ♦ K 10 6 ♣ K J 9 3
	♠ 8 7 5 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ Q J 8 5 ♣ A 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♥	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♥9

You should be sure you and partner are on the same page with this bid. A 2NT overcall over a Weak-2 opener shows the same hand as a 1NT overcall over a 1 of a suit opener. In other words, 15-18 points, and at least 1 (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit.

Partner, who is on the same page, bids 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥9. As expected, South leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

You need 5 more winners. This is important to keep in mind.

You can establish at most 1 winner in ♦s, 2 in ♠s, and 3 in ♣s. Since you must work on both ♠s and ♣s, you don't need to try for anything extra in ♦s.

If North has both black Aces you will go down, but you know that he cannot have two outside Aces with a 6-card ♥ suit headed by the Q J and still open with a weak 2-bid. So South must have at least one of the black Aces.

If you could guess which Ace North holds you could work on that suit first. He would win it, then get his ♥s established, but wouldn't be able to get back in to cash them.

But better than guessing, you should just holdup on the first ♥ trick and win the next one. Then it won't matter which Ace you knock out first because South will not have a ♥ to play in either case.

If you win the first trick and then play ♠s, you will be lucky. North will have to take his ♠A and then establish his ♥s. And when South takes the ♣A he won't have a ♥ to play.

If you win the first trick and then play ♣s, you will be unlucky. South will take his ♣A and play his last ♥. Then when North takes the ♠A he will set you with ♥ tricks.

If you hold up on first trick luck won't come into it. It will no longer matter which black suit you establish first.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 6 3 ♥ 8 4 2 ♦ Q 8 ♣ K Q 10 9 6	
♠ K 8 2 ♥ Q J 10 9 6 ♦ K 9 5 2 ♣ A	N W E S	♠ J 10 9 5 ♥ 7 3 ♦ J 10 7 4 ♣ 7 4 3
	♠ A 7 4 ♥ A K 5 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ J 8 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♥	3♣	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥Q

After the overcall of your partner's opening 1NT you must make a quick decision with this type of hand:Force to game or settle for partscore. Using lebensohl, a suit bid at the 3-level shows a 5-card or longer suit and is game forcing. You go for it by bidding 3♣ (not Stayman) and partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q. You must make an immediate decision whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

Of course the ♣ suit will produce 4 winners so you need just one more in ♠s or ♦s.

First the question of holding up or not. The reason for a hold-up play is to be sure that when East gains the lead he has no ♥s remaining. But in this Deal you can place most of the strength with West so you don't need to hold up. And, in fact, there is a good reason why you shouldn't.

Win the first trick with your ♥K and immediately play a ♣, taken by West's ♣A. He plays the ♥J which you win with your ♥A. East followed suit to the second ♥!

West has 3 ♥ winners in his hand. There is a good chance that he has the ♠K and ♦K as well. So if you play either of those suits, leading toward the Queen, West will jump up with his King and put you down 1. So instead, play a ♣ winner, and when West shows out, play your last ♥! West will smile as he takes his three ♥ winners but then he will frown when he realizes he must lead away from one of his Kings! You, of course, will jump up with dummy's Queen of that suit for your ninth trick.

We learn at bridge that you should lead toward high cards to try to establish them. For example, in this Deal leading toward the ♠Q would establish a winner as long as West held the ♠K. Unfortunately you would be giving up the setting trick as you established the winner.

Always keep in the back of your mind the possibility of an elimination play. In this Deal that meant you needed to refuse the hold-up because you would need the third ♥ to throw West in with.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 ♥ K Q 10 9 ♦ Q J 5 3 ♣ 9 5 4 2	
♠ 8 4 ♥ A 8 7 2 ♦ A 9 6 4 ♣ A K Q	N W E S	♠ A K 7 6 3 2 ♥ 6 5 3 ♦ 7 ♣ 10 8 6
	♠ Q J 9 5 ♥ J 4 ♦ K 10 8 2 ♣ J 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥K

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠. Partner now bids 3♠.

You wouldn't have chosen ♠s for a trump suit.

But you aren't doing the choosing, partner is. He has set the trump suit as ♠s and asks that you bid game if you have a maximum 1NT opening. So you bid 4♠, as instructed.

West plays 4♠. North leads ♥K, South plays ♥J. You have no reason to hold up so you win the ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Things look simple. You can afford one ♠ loser so as long as they split 3-2 you will succeed. So you play ♠A, ♠K; North follows to the first and discards a ♦ on the second.

OK, South has two trump tricks, but don't give up. Maybe, just maybe, there is a way out. Check your winners:You have won 3 tricks - ♥A and ♠ A K. You have 4 more top winners - ♦A and ♣ A K Q. If you can somehow add 3 more small trumps that will be the 10 you need.

Play dummy's ♦7 to your ♦A, then ruff a ♦. Play a ♣ to your hand and ruff another ♦. Play another ♣ to your hand and ruff your last ♦. While you are ruffing these three ♦s South is helplessly following suit.

Now play to your good ♣ while South again has to follow suit.

You have taken the first 10 tricks. Poor South is going to end up ruffing his partner's ♦ winner with one of his master trumps.

Trumps don't always split as evenly as you would like them to.

When they split badly, sometimes you can recover by ruffing with small trumps while the trump-heavy defender has to follow suit.

This is called "trump elopement".

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K J ♥ A 7 2 ♦ K Q 7 6 ♣ A 9 4	
♠ 10 9 4 2 ♥ J 10 4 3 ♦ 5 4 ♣ 10 8 5		♠ Q 5 3 ♥ K 9 6 ♦ 10 9 8 3 ♣ 7 6 2
	♠ 8 7 6 ♥ Q 8 5 ♦ A J 2 ♣ K Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♦10

Sometimes bidding is easy. Partner has 20 or 21 points, balanced. You have 13 points, balanced. Total = 33 or 34 points, balanced. So you close your eyes and bid 6NT.

The contract would be 6NT played by South.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♦10. Too bad East didn't lead a ♠. Oh, well.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

There is no way to get more than 4 winners in each minor suit, so you need to win either the ♠J or ♥Q.

Which one should you try?

Why not try both? If you make sure you try them in the right order you can have both chances.

Suppose you lead a small ♠ from dummy and play your ♠J, and it loses to East's ♠Q. If you then try leading a small ♥ toward dummy's ♥Q, obviously the defender with the ♥K will grab it to set the contract.

Instead, try the effect of leading toward the ♥Q first. If East has the ♥K then you will succeed in creating the extra winner you need. But what if you play the ♥Q and West takes it with his ♥K? Too bad, but at least you are not dead yet. You still have a chance to finesse West for the ♠Q.

Here is an important principle. There are two critical cards, the ♠Q and the ♥K. However they are not the same degree of criticality.

If the ♠Q is in a favorable position, (with West), you are always going to make your contract no matter which you try first.

But if only the ♥K is in a favorable position, (with East), you can make the contract only if you try ♥s first.